persisted with diplomatic engagement even in the midst of the ongoing border crisis in Eastern Ladakh.

At the same time, India has made sustained efforts to enhance its military and deterrent capabilities vis-à-vis China. One major component in India's internal balancing is the programme to build "strategic" roads in the border states. This became imperative because of the tremendous improvements to infrastructure in Tibet that China had effected since the 1990s. By the end of the 2000s, China had developed a 40,000-km road network in Tibet, built the Tibet–Qinghai railway, completed the Gormo–Lhasa electrified railway line with plans to extend it to Xigaze and Yatung in the Chumbi Valley, established new air bases, and built an oil pipeline with a capacity to transport five million tonnes a year. It has been estimated that this level of infrastructure would enable the PLA to deploy and maintain between 30 and 32 divisions, a two-thirds increase from the previous capacity of 20 to 22 divisions.[100] In response, the Indian government initiated the strategic roads programme in 2006 to build 73 roads totalling some 3812 km and nine strategic railway lines in order to improve connectivity and thus enhance the Army's ability to defend the border regions and states. Progress has, however, been extremely slow due to terrain and weather, as well as poor project management.[101]

A second component of India's internal balancing strategy is the strengthening of military capabilities along the China front. The most important idea in this regard been of a mountain strike corps for offensive operations against China. Originally envisaged as a force comprising more than 90,000 soldiers in two mountain divisions and armoured, artillery, air defence, and engineer brigades, changes are being made to the concept because of both its very high envisaged cost of nearly Rs 65,000 crore and the new idea of reorganising the Army into Integrated Battle Groups